Born in Moravia, in what was then the Austro-Hungarian Empire, Joseph Schumpeter moved to Vienna as a child, where he studied at the university. He then went on to teach at the universities of Czernowitz (modern-day Ukraine) and Graz (Austria). After World War I he was appointed Austrian Minister of Finance, and later President of the Biedermann Bank, before moving to the US in 1924. Like Marx he believed that the capitalist system is destructive, but he described the innovations brought by capitalism as “creative destruction.”

Amartya Sen (1933–)

Indian economist Amartya Sen was awarded the Nobel Prize in Economics in 1998 for his work in welfare economics, the study of how resources can best be allocated. He studied at the University of Calcutta (Kolkata) and then in Cambridge, UK, before taking up a career teaching at universities in India, the US, and the UK.

Herbert Simon (1916–2001)

A true polymath, Herbert Simon was a prominent thinker in many different fields, including psychology, sociology, computer science, and artificial intelligence—as well as politics and economics. Bringing together ideas from all these subjects, he was a pioneer of behavioral economics and especially the idea of “bounded rationality”, for which he was awarded the Nobel Prize for Economic Science in 1978.

Adam Smith (1723–1790)

Nicholas Stern (1946–)

British economist Nicholas Stern is a former vice president of the World Bank, but is better known as an adviser to the British government on the economics of climate change. As the head of a team commissioned by the UK Treasury, he published the Stern Review Report on the Economics of Climate Change in 2006, which described climate change as “a result of the greatest market failure the world has seen.”

George Stigler (1911–1991)

A leading member of the Chicago School of economics alongside Milton Friedman, George Stigler was a Nobel Prize winner in 1982. Born in Seattle, Washington, he studied at the University of Chicago, and after teaching at Columbia University in New York he returned to Chicago in 1958. In addition to his research into government behavior and the history of economics, Stigler was one of the first economists to explore the new field of information economics.

Joseph Stiglitz (1943–)

American economist Joseph Stiglitz became known for his work on information economics, and went on to become an economic adviser to President Bill Clinton in the 1990s, and then Chief Economist of the World Bank. He is critical of the prevailing free-market economics, and especially the way that globalization is managed by multinational companies and institutions such as the International Monetary Fund and World Bank.